# 8 Common Problems in Grammar and Usage

## Common Problems in Grammar

### Sentence Fragments

What is a sentence fragment? A sentence fragment is a broken chunk of sentence in need of fixing. The poor fractured thing can't stand alone. In this section, we'll look at some broken sentences and fix them, too.

Here are the fragments. Let's examine them one at a time.

> When the troll bounced off the bannister.
>
> Muttering over the cauldron.
>
> To harvest mandrakes nocturnally.
>
> In our preparation of the purple potion.
>
> Or lurk beneath the balustrade.

Say the first sentence fragment aloud: "When the troll bounced off the bannister." Say it again. Do you feel as if something is missing? Do the words trigger questions in your mind? "What?" "What happened?" That's great. You are reacting to a dependent clause that is being treated as if it were a sentence. But it isn't.

Here are a couple of ways to correct this fragment. You can simply chop off the subordinating conjunction *when*, leaving yourself with a simple sentence:

> The troll bounced off the bannister.

You can also provide the dependent clause with an independent clause to lean on:

> When the troll bounced off the bannister, **he bowled over the professor of herbology.**
>
> **The little wizards laughed to see such sport** when the troll bounced off the bannister.

Now for the second fragment, "Muttering over the cauldron." Again, something feels incomplete. This is either a participial phrase or a gerund phrase. It needs a subject; it also needs a complete verb. Here's the simplest way to repair the fragment:

> **The witch is** muttering over the cauldron.

Here's another:

> Muttering over the cauldron **is a bad habit that good witches should avoid.**

Here's a third:

> Muttering over the cauldron, **the witch failed to enunciate the incantation clearly.**

The third fragment again has several fixes. You can turn the infinitive phrase "To harvest mandrakes nocturnally" into a command:

> Harvest mandrakes nocturnally! (The professor of herbology does not recommend that you harvest them by day.)

You can provide a simple subject and complete the verb:

> **We will** harvest mandrakes nocturnally.

You can treat "To harvest mandrakes nocturnally" as the subject of your sentence and add a predicate:

> To harvest mandrakes nocturnally **is a task that only a fearless junior wizard would undertake.**

You can also keep "To harvest mandrakes nocturnally" as an infinitive phrase and attach it to an independent clause:

> To harvest mandrakes nocturnally, **you must wait for a completely moonless night.**

The next to last sentence fragment, "In our preparation of the purple potion," is a participial phrase.

To fix it, you can provide a simple subject and create a verb:

> **We prepared** the purple potion.

You can assume an implicit subject (*you*) and turn it into a command:

> **Prepare** the purple potion!

You can also attach it to an independent clause:

> **We miscalculated the proportions** in our preparation of the purple potion.

The final sentence fragment, "Or lurk beneath the balustrade," is part of a compound predicate. Take away the initial *Or* and you have a command:

> Lurk beneath the balustrade!

Provide a simple subject and you have a straightforward declarative sentence:

> **Orcs** lurk beneath the balustrade.

Combine the fragment with the other part or parts of the compound predicate, and you have a complete sentence:

> **Orcs slink around the cellarage** or lurk beneath the balustrade.

Here is a question involving a sentence fragment. See whether you can select the correct answer.

Some parts of the following sentence are underlined. The first answer choice, (A), simply repeats the underlined part of the sentence. The other four choices present four alternative ways to phrase the underlined part. Select the answer that produces the most effective sentence, one that is clear and exact. In selecting your choice, be sure that it is standard written English, and that it expresses the meaning of the original sentence.

Example:

J. K. Rowling, a British novelist, whose fame as an innovator in the field of fantasy may come to equal that of J. R. R. Tolkien.

(A) J. K. Rowling, a British novelist, whose fame as an innovator
(B) A British novelist who is famous as an innovator, J. K. Rowling
(C) J. K. Rowling, who is a British novelist and whose fame as an innovator
(D) J. K. Rowling is a British novelist whose fame as an innovator
(E) A British novelist, J. K. Rowling, who is a famous innovator

Did you spot that the original sentence was missing its verb? The sentence's subject is J. K. Rowling. She *is* a British novelist. That is the core of the sentence. Everything else in the sentence simply serves to clarify what kind of novelist Rowling is. She is a novelist whose fame may come to equal Tolkien's fame. The correct answer is choice D.

Try this second question, also involving a sentence fragment.

The new vacation resort, featuring tropical gardens and man-made lagoons, and overlooks a magnificent white sand beach.

(A) resort, featuring tropical gardens and man-made lagoons and overlooks a magnificent white sand beach
(B) resort overlooks a magnificent white sand beach, it features tropical gardens and man-made lagoons
(C) resort, featuring tropical gardens and man-made lagoons and overlooking a magnificent white sand beach
(D) resort, featuring tropical gardens and man-made lagoons, overlooks a magnificent white sand beach
(E) resort to feature tropical gardens and man-made lagoons and to overlook a magnificent white sand beach

What makes this a sentence fragment? Note the presence of *and* just before the verb *overlooks*. The presence of *and* immediately before a verb is a sign of a compound predicate, as in the sentence "The cauldron bubbled and overflowed." (*Definition*: A compound predicate consists of at least two verbs, linked by *and*, *or*, *nor*, *yet*, or *but*, that have a common subject.) But there is only one verb here, not two.

How can you fix this fragment? You can rewrite the sentence, substituting the verb *features* for the participle *featuring* so that the sentence has two verbs:

> The new vacation resort **features** tropical gardens and man-made lagoons and **overlooks** a magnificent white sand beach.

Or, you can simply take away the *and*. The sentence then would read:

> The new vacation resort, featuring tropical gardens and man-made lagoons, **overlooks** a magnificent white sand beach.

This sentence is grammatically complete. It has a subject, *resort*, and a verb, *overlooks*. The bit between the commas ("featuring...lagoons") simply describes the subject. (It's called a participial phrase.) The correct answer is choice D.

## The Run-On Sentence

The run-on sentence is a criminal connection operating under several aliases: the *comma fault sentence*, the *comma splice sentence*, the *fused sentence*. Fortunately, there's no need for you to learn the grammar teachers' names for these flawed sentences. You just need to know they are flawed.

Here are two run-on sentences. It's easy to spot the comma fault or comma splice: it's the one containing the comma.

EXAMPLE 1:

The wizards tasted the potion, they found the mixture tasty.

EXAMPLE 2:

The troll is very hungry I think he is going to pounce.

The *comma splice* or *comma fault* sentence is a sentence in which two independent, self-supporting clauses are improperly connected by a comma. Clearly, the two are in need of a separation if not a divorce. Example 1 above illustrates a comma splice or comma fault. The *fused sentence* (Example 2) consists of two sentences that run together without benefit of any punctuation at all. Such sentences are definitely *not* PG (Properly Grammatical).

You can correct run-on sentences in at least four different ways.

1. Use a period, not a comma, at the end of the first independent clause. Begin the second independent clause with a capital letter.

   The wizards tasted the potion. They found the mixture tasty.

   The troll is very hungry. I think he is going to pounce.

2. Connect the two independent clauses by using a coordinating conjunction.

   The wizards tasted the potion, and they found the mixture tasty.

   The troll is very hungry, so I think he is going to pounce.

3. Insert a semicolon between two main clauses that are not already connected by a coordinating conjunction.

   The wizards tasted the potion; they found the mixture tasty.

   The troll is very hungry; I think he is going to pounce.

4. Use a subordinating conjunction to indicate that one of the independent clauses is dependent on the other.

   When the wizards tasted the potion, they found the mixture tasty.

   Because the troll is very hungry, I think he is going to pounce.

Here is a question involving a run-on sentence. See whether you can select the correct answer.

> Some parts of the following sentence are underlined. The first answer choice, (A), simply repeats the underlined part of the sentence. The other four choices present four alternative ways to phrase the underlined part. Select the answer that produces the most effective sentence, one that is clear and exact. In selecting your choice, be sure that it is standard written English, and that it expresses the meaning of the original sentence.
>
> Example:
>
> Many students work after school and on weekends, consequently they do not have much time for doing their homework.
>
> (A) weekends, consequently they do not have
> (B) weekends, they do not have
> (C) weekends, as a consequence they do not have
> (D) weekends, therefore they do not have
> (E) weekends; consequently, they do not have

What makes this a run-on sentence? There are two main clauses here, separated by a comma. The rule is, use a comma between main clauses only when they are linked by a coordinating conjunction (*and, but, for, or, nor, so, yet*). There's no coordinating conjunction here, so you know the sentence as it stands is wrong. The main clauses here are linked by *consequently*, which is what grammar teachers call a conjunctive adverb. A rule also covers conjunctive adverbs. That rule is, use a semicolon before a conjunctive adverb set between two main clauses. Only one answer choice uses a semicolon before *consequently*: the correct answer, choice E.

# Problems with Agreement

## Subject-Verb Agreement

The verb and its subject must get along; otherwise, things turn nasty. The rule is that a verb and its subject must agree in person and number. A singular verb must have a singular subject; a plural verb must have a plural subject.

Here are some singular subjects, properly agreeing with their singular verbs:

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| I conjure | You lurk | She undulates |
| I am conjuring | You are lurking | He is ogling |
| I have conjured | You have lurked | It has levitated |

Here are the corresponding plural subjects with their plural verbs:

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| We pirouette | You pillage | They sulk |
| We are pirouetting | You are pillaging | They are sulking |
| We have pirouetted | You have pillaged | They have sulked |

Normally, it's simple to match a singular subject with an appropriate singular verb, or a plural subject with a plural verb. However, problems can arise, especially when phrases or parenthetical expressions separate the subject from the verb. Even the rudest intrusion is no reason for the subject and the verb to disagree.

A **cluster** of grapes **was** hanging just out of the fox's reach.

The **elixir** in these bottles **is** brewed from honey and rue.

The **dexterity** of her long, thin, elegant fingers **has** improved immeasurably since she began playing the vielle.

The **cabin** of clay and wattles **was** built by William Butler Yeats.

Parenthetical expressions are introduced by *as well as*, *with*, *along with*, *together with*, *in addition to*, *no less than*, *rather than, like*, and similar phrases. Although they come between the subject and the verb, they do not interfere with the subject and verb's agreement.

The **owl** together with the pussycat **has** gone to sea in a beautiful pea-green boat.

The **walrus** with the carpenter **is** eating all the oysters.

**Dorothy** along with the lion, the scarecrow, the woodman, and her little dog Toto **is** following the yellow brick road.

**Berenice** as well as Benedick **was** hidden under the cloak.

The Trojan **horse,** including the Greek soldiers hidden within it, **was** hauled through the gates of Troy.

**Henbane,** rather than hellebore or rue, **is** the secret ingredient in this potion.

**Henbane,** in addition to hops, **gives** the potion a real kick.

**I,** like the mandrake, **am** ready to scream.

Likewise, if a clause comes between the subject and its verb, it should not cause them to disagree. A singular subject still takes a singular verb.

The **troll** who lurched along the corridors **was** looking for the loo.

The **phoenix** that arose from the ashes **has** scattered cinders everywhere.

The **way** you're wrestling those alligators **is** causing them some distress.

A compound subject (two or more nouns or pronouns connected by *and*) traditionally takes a plural verb.

The walrus and the carpenter were strolling on the strand.

"The King and I," said Alice, "are on our way to tea."

However, there are exceptions. If the compound subject refers to a single person or thing, don't worry that it is made up of multiple nouns. Simply regard it as singular and follow it with a singular verb.

*The Lion, the Witch, and the Wardrobe*, written by C.S. Lewis, is an admirable tale.

The Eagle and Child is a pub in Oxford where Lewis and Tolkien regularly sampled the admirable ale.

Green eggs and ham was our family's favorite breakfast every St. Patrick's Day.

*The King and I* is a musical comedy.

Frodo's guide and betrayer literally bites the hand that feeds him. (Both *guide* and *betrayer* refer to the same creature, Gollum.)

(Note that the title of a work of art—a novel, poem, painting, play, opera, ballet, statue—*always* takes a singular verb, even if the title contains a plural subject. *The Burghers of Calais* is a statue by Rodin. The burgers of Burger King are whoppers.)

Some words are inherently singular. In American English, collective nouns like *team, community, jury, swarm, entourage,* and so on are customarily treated as singular.

The croquet team is playing brilliantly, don't you think?

The community of swamp dwellers has elected Pogo president.

The jury was convinced that Alice should be decapitated.

A swarm of bees is dive-bombing Willie Yeats.

My entourage of sycophants fawns on me in a most satisfying fashion.

However, when a collective noun is used to refer to *individual members* of a group, it is considered a plural noun.

The jury were unable to reach a verdict. (The individual jurors could not come to a decision.)

I hate it when my entourage of sycophants compete with one another for my attention. (This sentence is technically correct. However, it calls excessive attention to its correctness. In real life, you'd want to rewrite it. Here's one possible revision: I hate it when my hangers-on compete with one another for my attention.)

Sometimes the article used with a collective noun is a clue to whether the verb is singular or plural. The expressions *the number* and *the variety* generally are regarded as singular and take a singular verb. The expressions *a number* and *a variety* generally are regarded as plural and take a plural verb.

The number of angels able to dance on the head of a pin is limited by Fire Department regulations.

A number of angels able to dance on the head of a pin have been booked to perform at Radio City Music Hall.

The variety of potions concocted by the junior wizards is indescribable.

A variety of noises in the night have alarmed the palace guard. (Has Imogen been serenading Peregrine again?)

Some nouns look plural but refer to something singular. These nouns take singular verbs. Consider *billiards, checkers,* and *dominoes* (the game, not the pieces). Each is an individual game. What about *astrophysics, economics, ethics, linguistics, mathematics, politics, statistics* (the field as a whole, not any specific figures), and *thermodynamics?* Each is an individual discipline or organized body of knowledge. What about *measles, mumps,* and *rickets?* Each is an individual disease. Other camouflaged singular nouns are *customs* (as in baggage inspections at borders), *molasses, news*, and *summons*.

While dominoes is Dominick's favorite pastime, billiards is Benedick's.

The molasses in the potion disguises the taste of garlic and hellebore.

Rickets is endemic in trolls because of their inadequate exposure to sunlight. (Trolls who get adequate exposure to sunlight suffer instead from petrification.)

This summons to a midnight assignation was from Sybilla, not from Berenice.

Some plural nouns actually name single things that are made of two connected parts: *eyeglasses, knickers, pliers, scissors, sunglasses, tights, tongs, trousers, tweezers*. Don't let this confuse you. Just match them up with plural verbs.

Imogen's knickers are in a twist.

Peregrine's sunglasses are in the Lost and Found.

Watch out, however, when these plural nouns crop up in the phrase "a pair of...." The *scissors are* on the escritoire, but a *pair* of scissors *is* on the writing desk.

Watch out, also, when a sentence begins with *here* or *there*. In such cases, the subject of the verb *follows* the verb in the sentence.

There are many angels dancing on the head of this pin. [*Angels* is the subject of the verb *are*.]

Here is the pellet with the poison. [*Pellet* is the subject of the verb *is*.]

In the wizard's library there exist many unusual spelling books. [*Books* is the subject of the verb *exist*.]

Somewhere over the rainbow there lies the land of Oz. [*Land* is the subject of the verb *lies*.]

Likewise, watch out for sentences whose word order is inverted, so that the verb precedes the subject. In such cases, your mission is to find the actual subject.

Among the greatest treasures of all the realms is the cloak of invisibility.

Beyond the reckoning of man are the workings of a wizard's mind.

(An even greater mystery to men are the workings of a woman's mind....)

Here is a question involving subject-verb agreement.

> The following sentence may contain an error in grammar, usage, choice of words, or idioms. Either there is just one error in a sentence or the sentence is correct. Some words or phrases are underlined and lettered; everything else in the sentence is correct.
>
> If an underlined word or phrase is incorrect, choose that letter; if the sentence is correct, select No error.
>
> Example:
>
> Proficiency in (A) mathematics and language skills are (B) tested in (C) third grade and eighth grade as well as (D) in high school. No error (E)

Do not let yourself be fooled by nouns or pronouns that come between the subject and the verb. The subject of this sentence is *not* the plural noun *skills*. It is the singular noun, *proficiency*. The verb should be singular as well. The answer containing the subject-verb agreement error is choice B. To correct the error, substitute *is* for *are*.

## Pronoun-Verb Agreement

Watch out for errors in agreement between pronouns and verbs. (A pronoun is *not* a noun that has lost its amateur standing. Instead, it's a last-minute substitute, called upon to stand in for a noun that's overworked.) You already know the basic pronouns: *I, you, he, she, it, we, they* and their various forms. Here is an additional bunch of singular pronouns that, when used as subjects, typically team up with singular verbs.

Each of the songs Imogen sang was off-key. (Was that why her knickers were in a twist?)

Either of the potions packs a punch.

Neither of the orcs packs a lunch. (But, then, neither of the orcs is a vegetarian).

Someone in my entourage has been nibbling my chocolates.

Does anyone who is anyone go to Innisfree nowadays?

Everything is up to date in Kansas City.

Somebody loves Imogen; she wonders who.

Nobody loves the troll. (At least, no one admits to loving the troll. Everybody is much too shy.)

Does everyone really love Raymond?

Exception: Although singular subjects linked by *either...or* or *neither...nor* typically team up with singular verbs, a different rule applies when one subject is singular and one is plural. In such cases, proximity matters: the verb agrees with the subject nearest to it. (This rule also holds true when singular and plural subjects are linked by the correlative conjunctions *not only...but also* and *not...but*.)

Either the troll or the orcs have broken the balustrade.

Either the hobbits or the elf has hidden the wizard's pipe.

Neither the junior witches nor the professor of herbology has come up with a cure for warts.

Neither Dorothy nor her three companions were happy about carrying Toto everywhere.

Not only the oysters but also the walrus was eager to go for a stroll.

Not only Berenice but also Benedick and the troll have hidden under the cloak of invisibility.

Oddly enough, not the carpenter but the oysters were consumed by a desire to go for a stroll.

Not the elves but the dwarf enjoys messing about in caves.

The words *few, many,* and *several* are plural; they take a plural verb.

Many are cold, but few are frozen.

Several are decidedly lukewarm.

Here is a question involving pronoun-verb agreement.

> The following sentence may contain an error in grammar, usage, choice of words, or idioms. Either there is just one error in a sentence or the sentence is correct. Some words or phrases are underlined and lettered; everything else in the sentence is correct.
>
> If an underlined word or phrase is incorrect, choose that letter; if the sentence is correct, select No error.
>
> Example:
>
> Neither (A) the President nor the members of his Cabinet was (B) happy with (C) the reporter's account of dissension within (D) their ranks. No error (E)

Here we have one subject that is singular (*President*) and one that is plural (*members*). In such cases, the verb agrees with the subject nearest to it. *Members* is plural; therefore, the verb should be plural as well. Substitute *were* for *was*. The correct answer is choice B.

## Pronoun-Antecedent Agreement

A pronoun must agree with its antecedent in person, number, and gender. (The antecedent is the noun or pronoun to which the pronoun refers, or possibly defers.) Such a degree of agreement is unlikely, but in grammar (almost) all things are possible.

The munchkins welcomed Dorothy as she arrived in Munchkinland. (The antecedent *Dorothy* is a third person singular feminine noun; *she* is the third person singular feminine pronoun.)

Sometimes the antecedent is an indefinite singular pronoun: *any, anybody, anyone, each, either, every, everybody, everyone, neither, nobody, no one, somebody,* or *someone*. If so, the pronoun should be singular.

Neither of the twins is wearing his propeller beanie.

Each of the bronco-busters was assigned his or her own horse.

Anybody with any sense would refrain from serenading his inamorata on television.

When the antecedent is compound (two or more nouns or pronouns connected by *and*), the pronoun should be plural.

The walrus and the carpenter relished their outing with the oysters.

The walrus always takes salt in his tea.

Christopher Robin and I always have honey in ours.

You and your nasty little dog will get yours someday!

When the antecedent is part of an *either...or* or *neither...nor* statement, the pronoun will find it most politic to agree with the nearer antecedent.

Either Sybilla or Berenice always has the troll on her mind. (Actually, they both do, but in different ways.)

[Given the *either...or* construction, you need to check which antecedent is nearer to the pronoun. The ever-feminine, highly singular *Berenice* is; therefore, the correct pronoun is *her* rather than *their*.]

Neither the professor of herbology nor the junior wizards have finished digging up their mandrake roots. [*Wizards* is closer to *their*.]

Neither the hobbits nor the wizard has eaten all his mushrooms. [*Wizard* is closer to *his*.]

Here is a question involving pronoun-antecedent agreement.

> The following sentence may contain an error in grammar, usage, choice of words, or idioms. Either there is just one error in a sentence or the sentence is correct. Some words or phrases are underlined and lettered; everything else in the sentence is correct.
>
> If an underlined word or phrase is incorrect, choose that letter; if the sentence is correct, select No error.
>
> Example:
>
> Admirers of the vocal ensemble *Chanticleer*
>
> have come to wonder (A) over the years whether the group, known for their (B) mastery of Gregorian chant, might have abandoned its roots in (C) early music to explore (D) new musical paths. No error (E)

The error here is in choice B. The sentence is talking about a group. Is the group known for *their* mastery or for *its* mastery? *Group* is a collective noun. In American English collective nouns are usually treated as singular and take singular pronouns. Is that the case here? Yes. How can you be sure? Later in the sentence, a second pronoun appears: *its*. This pronoun refers back to the same noun: *group*. *Its* is *not* underlined. Therefore, by definition, the singular pronoun must be correct.

In solving error identification questions, remember that anything *not* underlined in the sentence is correct.

# Problems with Case

Now to get down to cases. In the English language, there are three: nominative (sometimes called subjective), possessive, and objective. Cases are special forms of words that signal how these words function in sentences. Most nouns, many indefinite pronouns, and a couple of personal pronouns reveal little about themselves: they have special case forms only for the possessive case (*Berenice's* cauldron, the *potion's* pungency, *its* flavor, *your* tastebuds, *anyone's* guess, *nobody's* sweetheart). Several pronouns, however, reveal much more, as the following chart demonstrates.

**Case Study**

| Nominative | Possessive | Objective |
|---|---|---|
| I | my/mine | me |
| we | our/ours | us |
| you | your/yours | you |
| he | his/his | him |
| she | her/hers | her |
| it | its/its | it |
| they | their/theirs | them |
| who | whose/whose | whom |

## The Nominative Case: *I, we, he, she, it, they, you, who*

The nominative case signals that the pronoun involved is functioning as the subject of a verb or as a subject complement.

> Ludovic and *I* purloined the Grey Poupon. [subject of verb]
>
> The only contestants still tossing gnomes were Berenice and *he.* [subject complement]
>
> The eventual winners—*he* and *she*—each received a keg of ale. [appositives identifying the subject]
>
> Sir Bedivere unhorsed the knight *who* had debagged Sir Caradoc. [subject in clause]

## The Possessive Case: *mine, ours, his, hers, theirs, yours; my, our, his, her, its, their, your, whose*

The possessive case signals ownership. Two-year-olds have an inherent understanding of the possessive: *Mine!*

> Drink to me only with *thine* eyes, and I will pledge with *mine*.
>
> Please remember that the walrus takes only salt in *his* tea, while Christopher Robin and I prefer honey in *ours*, and the Duchess enjoys a drop of Drambuie in *hers*.
>
> Ludovic put henbane in *whose* tea?

The possessive case also serves to indicate that a quality belongs to or is characteristic of someone or something.

> Her long, thin, elegant fingers once again demonstrated *their* dexterity.
>
> The troll rebounded at Berenice but failed to shake *her* composure.

A noun or pronoun immediately preceding a gerund (that is, a verbal that ends in *-ing* and acts like a noun) is in the possessive case.

The *troll's* bouncing into the bannister creates problems for passersby on the staircase. [*Troll's* immediately precedes the gerund *bouncing*.]

The troll would enjoy *his* bouncing more if Sybilla rather than Berenice caught him on the rebound. [*His* immediately precedes the gerund *bouncing*.]

## The Objective Case

Traditionally, the objective case indicates that a noun or pronoun receives whatever action is taking place. A pronoun in the objective case can serve as a direct object of a transitive verb, as an indirect object, as an object of a preposition, or, oddly enough, as the subject or object of an infinitive.

Berenice bounced *him* off the bannister again. [direct object]

The walrus gave *them* no chance to refuse his invitation to go for a stroll. [indirect object]

William Yeats, by *whom* the small cabin was built, was a better poet than carpenter. [object of preposition within a clause]

Peregrine expected *her* to serenade *him*. [subject and object of the infinitive *to serenade*.]

Be careful to use objective pronouns as objects of prepositions.

Everyone loves Raymond *except* Berenice and *me*.

Between you and *me,* I'm becoming suspicious of Sybilla and *him*.

Here are a couple of questions with problems involving case.

The following sentences may contain an error in grammar, usage, choice of words, or idioms. Either there is just one error in a sentence or the sentence is correct. Some words or phrases are underlined and lettered; everything else in the sentence is correct.

If an underlined word or phrase is incorrect, choose that letter; if the sentence is correct, select No error.

Example:

All of the flood victims except Lloyd and I
A
have decided to accept the settlement proposed by
B C D
the insurance company. No error
E

The object of the preposition *except* should be in the objective case. Change *I* to *me*. The error in the sentence is choice A.

Because the other jurors and her differed in their
A B C D
interpretation of the judge's instructions, they asked

for a clarification. No error
E

Here we have a compound subject. The subject of the initial clause ("Because...instructions") should be in the nominative case. Change *her* to *she*. The correct answer is choice B.

Many confusions about case involve compound subjects ("the other jurors and she") or compound objects of prepositions ("except Lloyd and me"). If you are having trouble recognizing which form of a pronoun to use, try reversing the noun-pronoun word order, or even dropping the noun. For example, instead of saying "Because the other jurors and her differed," try saying "Because her and the other jurors differed." Or simply say, "Because her differed." Does the pronoun sound odd to you? It should. When that happens, check whether the pronoun is in the right case.

# Problems Involving Modifiers

## Unclear Placement of Modifiers

Location, location, location. In general, adjectives, adverbs, adjective phrases, adverbial phrases, adjective clauses, and adverbial clauses need to be close to the word they modify. If these modifiers are separated from the word they modify, confusion may set in.

Some specific rules to apply:

1 Place the adverbs *only, almost, even, ever, just, merely,* and *scarcely* right next to the word they modify.

Ambiguous: The walrus *almost* ate all the oysters. (Did he just chew them up and spit them out without swallowing?)

Clear: The walrus ate *almost* all the oysters. (He left a few for the carpenter.)

Ambiguous: This elephant *only* costs peanuts.

Clear: *Only* this elephant costs peanuts. (The other elephants are traded for papayas and pomegranates.)

Clear: This elephant costs *only* peanuts. (What a cheap price for such a princely pachyderm!)

2 Place phrases close to the word they modify.

Unclear: The advertisement stated that a used cauldron was wanted by an elderly witch *with stubby legs*. (Obviously, the advertisement was not written to reveal the lady's physical oddity.)

Clear: The advertisement stated that a used cauldron *with stubby legs* was wanted by an elderly witch.

3 Place adjective clauses near the words they modify.

Misplaced: The owl and the pussycat bought a wedding ring from the pig *which cost one shilling*.

Clear: The owl and the pussycat bought a wedding ring *which cost one shilling* from the pig.

4 Words that may modify either a preceding or following word are called *squinting modifiers*. (They look both ways at once; no wonder they're walleyed.) To correct the ambiguity, move the modifier so that its relationship to one word is clear.

Squinting: Peregrine said that if Imogen refused to quit caterwauling beneath his balcony *in two minutes* he would send for the troll.

Clear: Peregrine said that he would send for the troll if Imogen refused to quit caterwauling beneath his balcony *in two minutes*.

Clear: Peregrine said that he would send for the troll *in two minutes* if Imogen refused to quit caterwauling beneath his balcony.

Squinting: The oysters agreed *on Sunday* to go for a stroll with the walrus.

Clear: *On Sunday*, the oysters agreed to go for a stroll with the walrus.

Clear: The oysters agreed to go for a stroll with the walrus *on Sunday*.

## Dangling Modifiers

When modifying phrases or clauses precede the main clause of a sentence, position is everything. These modifiers should come directly before the subject of the main clause and should clearly refer to that subject. If the modifiers foolishly hang out in the wrong part of the sentence, they may wind up dangling there making no sense at all.

To correct a dangling modifier, rearrange the words of the sentence to bring together the subject and its wayward modifier. You may need to add a few words to the sentence to clarify its meaning.

Dangling Participle: Walking down the Yellow Brick Road, the Castle of Great Oz was seen. (Did you ever see a castle walking? Well, I didn't.)

Corrected: Walking down the Yellow Brick Road, Dorothy and her companions saw the Castle of Great Oz. (The participle *walking* immediately precedes the subject of the main clause *Dorothy and her companions*.)

In the preceding example, the participial phrase comes at the beginning of the sentence. In the example below, the participial phrase follows the sentence base.

Dangling Participle: The time passed very enjoyably, singing songs and romping with Toto. (Who's that romping with Toto?)

Corrected: They passed the time very enjoyably, singing songs and romping with Toto.

Watch out for dangling phrases containing gerunds or infinitives.

Dangling Phrase Containing Gerund: Upon hearing the report that a troll had been found in the cellars, the building was cleared. (Again, ask yourself who heard the report. Even though the building was a school for wizards, its walls did *not* have ears.)

Corrected: Upon hearing the report that a troll had been found in the cellars, the headmaster cleared the building.

Dangling Phrase Containing Infinitive: Unable to defeat the Trojans in open battle, a trick was resorted to by the Greeks.

Corrected: Unable to defeat the Trojans in open battle, the Greeks resorted to a trick.

Be careful when you create elliptical constructions (ones in which some words are implied rather than explicitly stated) that you don't cut out so many words that you wind up with a dangling elliptical adverb clause.

Dangling Elliptical Construction: *When presented with the potion*, not one drop was drunk.

Corrected: *When presented with the potion, nobody* drank a drop.

Corrected: *When they were presented with the potion*, not one drop was drunk.

Yet Another Dangling Elliptical Construction: *Although only a small dog*, Dorothy found Toto a big responsibility.

Corrected: *Although Toto was only a small dog*, Dorothy found him a big responsibility.

Here are a couple of questions involving misplaced modifiers:

Some parts of the following sentences are underlined. The first answer choice, (A), simply repeats the underlined part of the sentence. The other four choices present four alternative ways to phrase the underlined part. Select the answer that produces the most effective sentence, one that is clear and exact. In selecting your choice, be sure that it is standard written English, and that it expresses the meaning of the original sentence.

Example:

Returning to Harvard after three decades, the campus seemed much less cheery to Sharon than it had been when she was studying there.

(A) Returning to Harvard after three decades, the campus seemed much less cheery to Sharon
(B) After Sharon returned to Harvard in three decades, it seemed a much less cheery campus to her
(C) Having returned to Harvard after three decades, it seemed a much less cheery campus to Sharon
(D) When Sharon returned to Harvard after three decades, she thought the campus much less cheery
(E) Sharon returned to Harvard after three decades, and then she thought the campus much less cheery

Did you recognize that the original sentence contains a dangling modifier? Clearly, the campus did not return to Harvard; Sharon returned to Harvard. By replacing the participial phrase with a subordinate clause ("When...decades") and by making *she* the subject of the sentence, choice D corrects the error in the original sentence.

Try this second question, also involving a dangling modifier.

Having drafted the museum floor plan with exceptional care, that the planning commission rejected his design upset the architect greatly.

(A) that the planning commission rejected his design upset the architect greatly
(B) the planning commission's rejection of his design caused the architect a great upset
(C) the architect found the planning commission's rejection of his design greatly upsetting
(D) the architect was greatly upset about the planning commission rejecting his design
(E) the architect's upset at the planning commission's rejection of his design was great.

Again, ask yourself who drafted the museum floor plan. Clearly, it was the architect. *Architect,* therefore, must be the sentence's subject. The correct answer must be either choice C or choice D. Choice D, however, introduces a fresh error. The phrase "rejecting his design" is a gerund. As a rule, you should use the possessive case before a gerund: to be correct, the sentence would have to read "the architect was greatly upset about the planning commission's rejecting his design. Choice D, therefore, is incorrect. The correct answer is choice C.

# Common Problems in Usage

## Words Often Misused or Confused

Errors in *diction*—that is, choice of words—have frequently been tested on the SAT II Writing Test and the Writing Section of the PSAT. You can be sure they'll crop up on the Writing Section of the new SAT. Here are some of the most common diction errors to watch for:

**accept/except.** These two words are often confused. *Accept* means to take or receive; to give a favorable response to something; to regard as proper. *Except*, when used as a verb, means to preclude or exclude. (*Except* may also be used as a preposition or a conjunction.)

Benedick will *accept* the gnome-tossing award on Berenice's behalf.

The necromancer's deeds were so nefarious that he was *excepted* from the general pardon. In other words, they pardoned everyone *except* him.

**affect/effect.** *Affect*, used as a verb, means to influence or impress, and to feign or assume. *Effect*, used as a verb, means to cause or bring about.

When Berenice bounced the troll against the balustrade, she *effected* a major change in his behavior.

The blow *affected* him conspicuously, denting his skull and his complacency.

To cover her embarrassment about the brawl, Berenice *affected* an air of nonchalance.

*Effect* and *affect* are also used as nouns. *Effect* as a noun means result, purpose, or influence. *Affect*, a much less common noun, is a psychological term referring to an observed emotional response.

Did being bounced against the balustrade have a beneficial *effect* on the troll?

The troll's *affect* was flat. So was his skull.

**aggravate.** *Aggravate* means to worsen or exacerbate. Do not use it as a synonym for *annoy* or *irritate*.

The orc will *aggravate* his condition if he tries to toss any gnomes so soon after his operation.

The professor of herbology was *irritated* [not *aggravated*] by the mandrakes' screams.

**ain't.** *Ain't* is nonstandard. Avoid it.

**already/all ready.** These expressions are frequently confused. *Already* means previously; *all ready* means completely prepared.

The mandrakes have *already* been dug up.

Now the mandrakes are *all ready* to be replanted.

**alright.** Use *all right* instead of the misspelling *alright*. (Is that *all right* with you?)

**altogether/all together.** *All together* means as a group. *Altogether* means entirely, completely.

The walrus waited until the oysters were *all together* on the beach before he ate them.

There was *altogether* too much sand in those oysters.

**among/between.** Use *among* when you are discussing more than two persons or things; *between*, when you are limiting yourself to only two persons or things.

The oysters were divided *among* the walrus, the carpenter, and the troll.

The relationship *between* Berenice and Benedick has always been a bit kinky.

**amount/number.** Use *amount* when you are referring to mass, bulk, or quantity. Use *number* when the quantity can be counted.

We were amazed by the *amount* of henbane the troll could eat without getting sick.

We were amazed by the *number* of hens the troll could eat without getting sick.

**and etc.** The *and* is unnecessary. Cut it.

**being as/being that.** These phrases are nonstandard; avoid them. Use *since* or *that*.

**beside/besides.** These words are often confused. *Beside* is always a preposition. It means "next to" or, sometimes, "apart from." Watch out for possible ambiguities or ambiguous possibilities. "No one was seated at the Round Table *beside* Sir Bedivere" has two possible meanings.

No one was seated at the Round Table *beside* Sir Bedivere. [There were empty seats on either side of Bedivere; however, Sir Kay, Sir Gawain, and Sir Galahad were sitting across from him on the other side of the table.]

No one was seated at the Round Table *beside* Sir Bedivere. [Poor Bedivere was all alone.]

*Besides*, when used as a preposition, means "in addition to" or "other than."

*Besides* oysters, the walrus and the carpenter have eaten countless cockles and mussels and clams.

Who will go to the bear-baiting *besides* Berenice and Benedick?

*Besides* also is used as an adverb. At such times, it means moreover or also.

The troll broke the balustrade—and the newel post *besides*.

**between.** See *among*.

**but what.** Avoid this phrase. Use *that* instead.

Wrong: Imogen could not believe *but what* Peregrine would overlook their assignation.

Better: Imogen could not believe *that* Peregrine would overlook their assignation.

**can't hardly/can't scarcely.** You have just encountered the dreaded double negative. (I *can hardly* believe anyone writes that way, can you?) Use *can hardly* or *can scarcely*.

**conscious/conscience.** Do not confuse these words. *Conscious*, an adjective, means aware and alert; it also means deliberate.

Don't talk to Berenice before she's had her morning cup of coffee; she isn't really *conscious* until she has some caffeine in her system.

When Ludovic laced the professor's potion with strychnine, was he making a *conscious* attempt to kill the prof?

*Conscience*, a noun, means one's sense of right and wrong.

Don't bother appealing to the orc's *conscience*: he has none.

**could of.** This phrase is nonstandard. Substitute *could have.*

**different from/different than.** Current usage accepts both forms; however, a Google check indicates that *different from* is the more popular usage.

**effect.** See *affect.*

**farther/further.** Some writers use the adverb *farther* when discussing physical or spatial distances; *further*, when discussing quantities. Most use them interchangeably. The adjective *further* is a synonym for *additional*.

Benedick has given up gnome-tossing contests because Berenice always tosses her gnomes yards *farther* than Benedick can toss his. [adverb]

This elixir is *further* enriched by abundant infusions of henbane and hellebore. [adverb]

Stay tuned for *further* announcements of the latest results in today's gnome-tossing state finals. [adjective]

**fewer/less.** Use *fewer* with things that you can count (one hippogriff, two hippogriffs...); *less*, with things that you cannot count but can measure in other ways.

"There are *fewer* oysters on the beach today than yesterday, I fear. How sad!" said the carpenter, and brushed away a tear.

Berenice should pay *less* attention to troll tossing and more to divination and elementary herbology.

**former/latter.** Use *former* and *latter* only when you discuss two items. (*Former* refers to the first item in a series of two; *latter*, to the second.) When you discuss a series of three or more items, use *first* and *last*.

Who was madder, the March Hare or the Hatter? Was it the *former*, or was it the *latter* (the Hatter)?

Though the spoon, the knife, and the fork each asked the dish to elope, everyone knows the dish ran away with the *first*.

**further.** See *farther.*

**had of/had have.** These phrases are nonstandard. Substitute *had*.

Do Not Write: If Benedick had of [nonstandard] tossed the gnome a foot farther, he could of [also nonstandard] won the contest.

Write: If Benedick *had* tossed the gnome a foot farther, he *could have* won the contest.

**hanged/hung.** Both words are the past participle of the verb *hang*. However, in writing formal English, use *hanged* when you are discussing someone's execution; use *hung* when you are talking about the suspension of an object.

Ludovic objected to being *hanged* at dawn, saying he wouldn't get up that early for anybody's execution, much less his own.

The stockings were *hung* from the chimney with care.

**hardly/scarcely.** These words are sufficiently negative on their own that you don't need any extra negatives (like *not, nothing,* or *without*) to get your point across. In fact, if you do add that extra *not* or *nothing,* you've perpetrated the dreaded double negative.

Do Not Write: The walrus couldn't hardly eat another bite.

Write: The walrus *could hardly* eat another bite.

Do Not Write: Compared to the walrus, the carpenter ate hardly nothing.

Write: Compared to the walrus, the carpenter ate *hardly anything* (or anyone).

Do Not Write: The troll pounced without scarcely a moment's hesitation.

Write: The troll pounced *with scarcely* a moment's hesitation.

**imply/infer.** People often use these words interchangeably to mean hint at or suggest. However, *imply* and *infer* have precise meanings that you need to tell apart. *Imply* means to suggest something without coming right out and saying it. *Infer* means to draw a conclusion, basing it on some sort of evidence.

When Auntie Em said, "My! That's a big piece of pie, young lady," did she mean to *imply* that Dorothy was being a glutton in taking such a huge slice?

Dorothy *inferred* from Auntie Em's comment that she'd better not ask for a second piece.

Imogen *inferred* from the fresh dent in the troll's skull that Berenice had been bouncing him off the balustrade again.

**in back of.** Avoid this expression. Use *behind* instead.

**incredible/incredulous.** *Incredible* means unbelievable, too improbable to be believed. *Incredulous* means doubtful or skeptical, unwilling to believe.

When Ludovic saw Berenice juggling three trolls in the air, he was amazed at her *incredible* strength.

Do you believe all this jabber about Berenice's strength, or are you *incredulous?*

**irregardless.** This nonstandard usage particularly irritates graders. Use *regardless* instead.

**kind of/sort of.** In writing formal prose, avoid using these phrases adverbially (that is, with the meaning of *somewhat* or *to a degree*, as in "kind of bashful" or "sort of infatuated.") Use words like *quite*, *rather*, or *somewhat* instead.

Informal: Dorothy was kind of annoyed by the wizard's obfuscations.

Approved: Dorothy was *quite* annoyed by the wizard's obfuscations.

**kind of a/sort of a.** In writing formal prose, cut out the *a*.

Do Not Write: Sybilla seldom brews this kind of a potion.

Write: Sybilla seldom brews this *kind of* potion.

**last/latter.** See *former.*

**later/latter.** Use *later* when you're talking about time (you'll do it sooner or later). Use *latter* when you're talking about the second one of a group of two (not the former—that comes first—but the latter).

Every night Imogen stays up *later* and *later* serenading Peregrine.

Berenice tossed both the troll and a gnome. The *latter* bounced farther.

**lay/lie.** *Lay,* a transitive verb, means to put or place. *Lie,* an intransitive verb, means to rest or recline. One way to tell whether to use *lay (laying, laid)* or *lie (lying, lay, lain)* is to examine the sentence. If the verb has an object, use the correct form of *lay.* If the verb has no object, use *lie.*

Toto, *lie* down and roll over!

Toto *lay* down on the floor. [*Lay* is past tense of *lie*.]

Auntie Em, Toto's just *lying* there. He's not rolling over!

How long *has* he *lain* there, Dorothy? Maybe he's taking a nap. [The verb has no object. *Has lain* is the present perfect tense of *lie*.]

Berenice, please *lay* the troll down gently. [Object is *troll*.]

Instead of *laying* the troll down, Berenice bounced him off the bannister.

Ludovic *laid* the loot on the escritoire. [Object is *loot*. *Laid* is past tense of *lay*.]

**learn/teach.** *Learn* means to get knowledge; *teach* means to instruct, to give knowledge or information. Don't confuse the two.

| | |
|---|---|
| Incorrect: | I'll learn you, you stupid troll! |
| Correct: | I'll *teach* you, you obtuse orc! |

**leave/let.** *Leave* primarily means to depart; *let,* to permit. Don't confuse them. (*Leave*, when followed by an object and an infinitive or a participial phrase, as in "Leave him to do his worst" or "Leave it to Beaver," has other meanings. Consult an unabridged dictionary.)

| | |
|---|---|
| Incorrect: | Leave me go, Berenice. |
| Correct: | *Let* me go, Berenice. Please *let* me leave. |

**less.** See *fewer.*

**liable to/likely to.** *Likely to* refers simply to probability. When speaking informally, people are likely to use *liable to* in place of *likely to*. However, in formal writing, *liable to* conveys a sense of possible harm or misfortune.

| | |
|---|---|
| Informal: | The owl and the pussycat are liable to go for a sail. [This is a simple statement of probability. More formally, you would write "The owl and the pussycat are likely to go for a sail."] |
| Preferable: | The beautiful but leaky pea-green boat is *liable to* sink. [This conveys a sense of likely danger.] |

**lie.** See *lay.*

**loose/lose.** These are not synonyms. *Loose* is primarily an adjective meaning free or inexact or not firmly fastened ("a *loose* prisoner," "a *loose* translation," "a *loose* tooth.") As a verb, *loose* means to set free or let fly.

*Loose* the elephants!

The elf *loosed* his arrows at the orcs.

*Lose* is always a verb.

If the elf *loses* any more arrows in the bushes, he won't have any left to loose at the orcs.

Hey, baby, *lose* the sidekick, and you and I can have a good time.

**me and.** Unacceptable as part of a compound subject.

| | |
|---|---|
| Nonstandard: | Me and Berenice can beat any three trolls in the house. |
| Preferred: | Berenice *and I* can beat any three trolls in the house. (Actually, Berenice can beat them perfectly well without any help from me.) |

**number.** See *amount*.

**of.** Don't write *of* in place of *have* in the expressions *could have, would have, should have, must have,* and so on.

**off of.** In formal writing, the *of* is superfluous. Cut it.

| | |
|---|---|
| Incorrect: | The troll bounced off of the bannister. |
| Correct: | The troll bounced *off* the bannister. |

**principal/principle.** Do not confuse the adjective *principal,* meaning chief, with the noun *principle,* a rule or law.

Berenice's *principal principle* (that is, her chief rule of conduct) is "The bigger they are, the harder they bounce."

In a few cases, *principal* is used as a noun: the *principal* of a loan (the main sum you borrowed); the *principal* in a transaction (the chief person involved in the deal); the *principal* of a school (originally the head teacher). Don't worry about these instances. If you can substitute the word *rule* for the noun in your sentence, then the word you want is *principle*.

**raise/rise.** Do not confuse the verb *raise (raised, raising)* with *rise (rose, risen, rising)*. *Raise* means to increase, to lift up, to collect, or to nurture. It is transitive (it takes an object). *Rise* means to ascend, to get up, or to grow. It is intransitive (no objects need apply).

| | |
|---|---|
| Incorrect: | They are rising the portcullis. |
| Correct: | They are *raising* the portcullis. [The object is portcullis, a most heavy object indeed.] |
| Incorrect: | The sun raised over the battlements. |
| Correct: | The sun *rose* over the battlements. |

**real.** This word is an adjective meaning genuine or concrete. Do not use it as an adverb meaning very or extremely.

| | |
|---|---|
| Too Informal: | This is a real weird list of illustrative sentences. |
| Preferable: | This is a *really* weird list of illustrative sentences. |
| Even Better: | This is an *extremely* weird list of illustrative sentences. |

**the reason is because.** This expression is ungrammatical. If you decide to use the phrase *the reason is*, follow it with a concise statement of the reason, not with a *because* clause.

| | |
|---|---|
| Incorrect: | *The reason* the oysters failed to answer *is because* the walrus and the carpenter had eaten every one. |
| Correct But Wordy: | *The reason* the oysters failed to answer *is that* the walrus and the carpenter had eaten every one. |
| Correct & Concise: | The oysters failed to answer *because* the walrus and the carpenter had eaten every one. |

**same.** Lawyers and writers of commercial documents sometimes use *same* as a pronoun. In writing essays, use the pronouns *it, them, this, that* in its place.

| | |
|---|---|
| Incorrect: | I have received your billet-doux and will answer same once my messenger owl returns home. |
| Correct: | I have received your billet-doux and will answer *it* once my messenger owl returns home. |

**scarcely.** See *hardly.*

**sort of.** See *kind of.*

**teach.** See *learn.*

**try and.** Avoid this phrase. Use *try to* in its place.

| | |
|---|---|
| Incorrect: | We must try and destroy the Ring of the Enemy. |
| Correct: | We must *try to* destroy the Ring of the Enemy. |

**unique.** The adjective *unique* describes something that is the only one of its kind. Don't qualify this adjective by *more, most, less, least, slightly,* or *a little bit*. It's just as illogical to label something a little bit unique as it is to describe someone as a little bit pregnant.

| | |
|---|---|
| Incorrect: | Only the One Ring has the power to rule elves, dwarfs, and mortal men. It is most unique. |
| Correct: | Only the One Ring has the power to rule elves, dwarfs, and mortal men. It is *unique.* |

# Picking Proper Prepositions

Occasionally, you may get back papers from your teachers with certain expressions labeled "unidiomatic." Often these errors involve prepositions. When you are in doubt about what preposition to use after a particular word, look up that word in an unabridged dictionary. Meanwhile, look over the list below to see which preposition customarily accompanies the following words.

**accede to**

Sybilla graciously *acceded to* Peregrine's request to compose a villanelle.

**according to**

*According to* Abelard, Esperanto is the language of love.

**accuse of**

Berenice vociferously *accused* the troll *of* borrowing her leotard.

**addicted to**

The professor of herbology is reputedly *addicted to* comfrey tea.

**adhere to**

Muttering the conjunction spell under his breath, the wizard *adhered* the brigand *to* the bottom of the balcony.

**adverse to**

Imogen is *adverse to* Peregrine's writing verse to other women.

**afflict with**

The wizard *afflicted* the brigand *with* borborygmus and boils.

**agree on** (come to terms)

The owl and the pussycat could not *agree on* what color to repaint their pea-green boat.

**agree with** (suit; be similar to; be consistent with)

Burping miserably, the carpenter confessed that a diet of oysters did not *agree with* him.

**agreeable to**

The troll found tiddlywinks an occupation most *agreeable to* his tastes.

**amazement at**

Imagine Imogen's *amazement at* discovering the brigand dangling from the bottom of the balcony!

**amenable to**

Excessively *amenable to* persuasion, Imogen is the archetypal girl who can't say no.

**appetite for**

The walrus had an insatiable *appetite for* oysters.

**appreciation of**

The troll's *appreciation of* the fine points of pillaging was sadly limited.

**aside from**

The professor of potions had run out of ingredients, *aside from* a few sprigs of dried hellebore.

**associate with**

Dorothy's Auntie Em warned her not to *associate with* lions and tigers and bears.

**blame for**, **blame on**

Orcs never *blame* themselves *for* ravaging the environment; instead, they *blame* the damage *on* the trolls.

**capable of**

Who knows what vile and abhorrent deeds trolls are *capable of?*

**chary of**

Snow White was insufficiently *chary of* accepting apples from strange old women.

**compatible with**

Is Peregrine *compatible with* Imogen? I doubt it!

**comply with**

Sybilla was reluctant to *comply with* the troll's incessant importuning.

**conform to** (occasionally **conform with**)

Apprentice wizards are expected to obey their masters and *conform to* proper wizardly practices.

**conversant with**

Anyone *conversant with* trolls' table manners knows better than to invite one to tea.

**desire for**

Even Sybilla's *desire for* new experiences could not tempt her to elope with the troll.

**desirous of**

Being *desirous of* a salad for dinner, Gargantua cut some heads of lettuce as large as walnut trees.

**desist from**

If the troll does not *desist from* importuning Sybilla, she's going to sic Berenice on him.

**die of**

When Homer's belching drowned out her saxophone solo, Lisa nearly *died of* embarrassment.

**different from**

In what way is Tweedledum *different from* Tweedledee? I thought they were exactly alike.

**disagree with**

Hellebore *disagreed with* the pygmy, causing his stomach to rumble. (The pygmy had borborygmi.)

**disdain for**

The immaculate elves were too polite to show their *disdain for* the unkempt orcs.

**enamored of**

The troll is *enamored of* Sybilla, who in turn is *enamored of* Benedick.

**indulge in**

Berenice *indulges in* the curious hobby of tossing trolls.

**inferior to**

The orcs' perfunctory grooming was *inferior to* the elves' more meticulous toilette.

**oblivious to**

Imogen is *oblivious to* Peregrine's flaws and all too aware of his perfection.

**partial to**

The walrus is extremely *partial to* oysters; he likes them too much for their own good.

**peculiar to**

A total aversion to sunlight is a condition *peculiar to* vampires and trolls.

**preoccupation with**

The troll could not comprehend Sybilla's *preoccupation with* Benedick.

**prevent from**

There is nothing we can do to *prevent* Berenice *from* bouncing the troll off the balustrade. We'll have to catch him on the rebound.

**prior to**

*Prior to* eating the oysters, the walrus and the carpenter took them for a stroll.

**prone to**

Imogen is *prone to* infatuations. Just ask Peregrine.

**separate from**

No wicked witch could *separate* Dorothy *from* her little dog Toto.

**tamper with**

Do not *tamper with* the purple potion.

**weary of**

Will Berenice ever *weary of* bouncing the troll off the balustrade?

**willing to**

I'm *willing to* bet that she won't.

## The Vagaries of Verbs

Verbs are the shape-shifters of the English language. They change their forms to indicate **person** (*who* is acting), **number** (*how many* are acting), **tense** (*when* the action is happening), **voice** (whether something is acting, as in being *active*, or is being acted upon, or *passive*), and **mood.**

Mood is the best. What's your mood? Do you feel like ordering someone around?

"Lurk!" you command. That's the *imperative* mood.

"Please lurk," you request. The mood's still imperative, but polite.

Then there's the *indicative* mood. If you're making a simple statement, indicating or pointing out something, or asking a straightforward question, you're using the indicative mood.

"The troll is lurking in the bushes."

"What do you think he wants?"

Finally, there's the *subjunctive* mood. You use the subjunctive when things are a bit iffy:

**(statement contrary to fact)**
"If I *were* the troll, I *would head* for the hills now." (Why should the troll head for the hills? Berenice is about to pounce.)

**(recommendation)**
"When I find the troll, I will suggest that he *hide*."

Some verbs are *regular*: when they shift into the past tense, they do it in the standard way by adding *-ed* or *-d*.

The troll lurk**ed.**

Berenice pounce**d.**

Others, however, are *irregular*: when they form the past tense, they either change in unusual ways (*think* becomes *thought*), or they don't change at all (*put* stays the same).

Here is a list of irregular verbs, showing the correct forms for the present tense, past tense, and past participle. Many you know already, but some will be unfamiliar to you. Don't let their shifts in form fool you when you run into them on the SAT.

## Irregular Verbs

| Present Tense | Past Tense | Past Participle |
|---|---|---|
| arise | arose | arisen |
| awake | awaked, awoke | awaked, awoke |
| bear | bore | borne |
| beat | beat | beaten |
| befall | befell | befallen |
| begin | began | begun |
| bend | bent | bent |
| bid (command) | bade | bidden |
| bid (command) | bid | bid |
| bind | bound | bound |
| blow | blew | blown |
| break | broke | broken |
| bring | brought | brought |
| broadcast | broadcast, broadcasted | broadcast, broadcasted |
| build | built | built |
| burst | burst | bust |
| buy | bought | bought |
| cast | cast | cast |

| Present Tense | Past Tense | Past Participle |
|---|---|---|
| catch | caught | caught |
| choose | chose | chosen |
| cling | clung | clung |
| come | came | come |
| creep | crept | crept |
| deal | dealt | dealt |
| dive | dived, dove | dived |
| do | did | done |
| draw | drew | drawn |
| drink | drank | drunk |
| drive | drove | driven |
| eat | ate | eaten |
| fall | fell | fallen |
| feed | fed | fed |
| feel | felt | felt |
| fight | fought | fought |
| find | found | found |
| flee | fled | fled |
| fling | flung | flung |
| fly | flew | flown |
| forebear | forbore | forborne |
| forbid | forbade | forbidden |
| forget | forgot | forgotten, forgot |
| forgive | forgave | forgiven |
| forsake | forsook | forsaken |
| freeze | froze | frozen |
| get | got | got, gotten |
| give | gave | given |
| go | went | gone |
| grow | grew | grown |
| hang* | hung, hanged* | hung, hanged* |
| have | had | had |
| hit | hit | hit |
| hold | held | held |
| kneel | knelt, kneeled | knelt |
| know | knew | known |
| lay | laid | laid |
| lead | led | led |
| leave | left | left |
| lend | lent | lent |
| lie | lay | lain |
| lose | lost | lost |
| make | made | made |
| meet | met | met |
| put | put | put |

*See the list of Words Often Misused or Confused (page 282).

| Present Tense | Past Tense | Past Participle |
|---|---|---|
| read | read | read |
| ring | rang | rung |
| rise | rose | risen |
| run | ran | run |
| see | saw | seen |
| seek | sought | sought |
| sell | sold | sold |
| send | sent | sent |
| set | set | set |
| shine | shone | shone |
| shrink | shrank, shrunk | shrunk, shrunken |
| sing | sang | sung |
| sink | sank | sunk |
| slay | slew | slain |
| sit | sat | sat |
| sleep | slept | slept |
| slide | slid | slid |
| sling | slung | slung |
| slink | slunk | slunk |
| speak | spoke | spoken |
| spring | sprang, sprung | sprung |
| steal | stole | stolen |
| stick | stuck | stuck |
| sting | stung | stung |
| stride | strode | stridden |
| strike | struck | struck |
| swear | swore | sworn |
| sweat | sweat, sweated | sweated |
| sweep | swept | swept |
| swim | swam | swum |
| swing | swung | swung |
| take | took | taken |
| teach | taught | taught |
| tear | tore | torn |
| telecast | telecast, telecasted | telecast, telecasted |
| tell | told | told |
| think | thought | thought |
| thrive, thrived | throve, thriven | throve, thriven |
| throw | threw | thrown |
| wake | waked, woke | waked, woken |
| wear | wore | worn |
| weep | wept | wept |
| win | won | won |
| wind | wound | wound |
| work | worked, wrought | worked, wrought |
| wring | wrung | wrung |
| write | wrote | written |